



the needs of the individual or team.

Many of these gadgets may not be 100 per cent accurate, but they can provide everything you need to know in an understandable format.

Availability of the athletes

While many claim that sports scientists can reduce athlete injuries, the main aim of sports science is, in fact, to improve availability. Having precise information through load monitoring and its interpretation helps highlight injury risks and should allow for necessary modifications in training programmes.

One might need to step down or step up the intensity of their exercise regime — or even adjust specific skill sets (still debatable) — in order to prevent injuries and manage recovery in tandem with training. More studies are still needed in the fields of load management, injury prevention, and recovery. Hitting the right chord is crucial to eliminating recurring issues.

Time is money, money is time

In a high-performance environment, owners or clubs simply can't afford to have millions of dollars sitting on the sidelines. In this context, sports science plays a vital role — whether it's getting a player

back into the game after injury, enhancing performance through specialised training, or understanding the needs of the team to design a winning concoction in tandem with the coaches and support staff.

Sports science helps in understanding the complete physiological and psychological domains through a scientific approach and validated methods. Many times, the information provided by the sports science team aids in making informed decisions about when players should be introduced into physically demanding situations.

Many sports scientists serve as the link between data and coaches. They inform high-performance teams about athletes who are at potential risk of injury and those who could be pushed a little harder. Watching these athletes sit on the sidelines with injuries, we often feel it could have been prevented — if only they had just listened. This is based on fact, not speculation. We could tell you how far an athlete had run, their heart rate variability at any point during training or a match, their maximum speeds, deceleration, propulsion, rotation, and overall wellness scores.

It is this information that creates a picture — and it is this picture that

Perfect harmony: Human wisdom and technology must work in tandem to create world-beaters. It's a concoction of science and belief — both necessary for excellence. GETTY IMAGES

allows the sports science team to determine whether athletes are available to train and compete at every level.

Demand and supply

I personally believe that the hype around sports science reflects a genuine need of the hour in India, with many subject areas being introduced through technical and tactical collaboration to create our own bespoke model for the country. We need to step up — not only in terms of infrastructure, but also by bringing in the right people and software to run the system professionally and efficiently. Simply building the infrastructure without qualified personnel would be a white elephant in the long run. Winning and losing can be the difference between mediocrity and excellence. When millions are being spent, there must be a shift in the narrative on the big stage. Sports science can be the tool to reach that goal.